

Network Delaware

Nathan Sanchez

School and Community Partnership Toolkit

I. Purpose of This Toolkit

This toolkit gives Network Delaware staff, school administrators, and community organization leaders what they need to start, maintain, and strengthen school-community partnerships grounded in the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework. It targets Front 3 of the framework (School-Based Partnerships and Hands-On Civic Practice) while drawing on the community-rooted power-building goals of Front 2. All tools, protocols, and resources in this document were developed with attention to Delaware's specific demographic landscape, including immigrant and mixed-status families, Black and Brown youth, Hispanic and Latino communities, disabled students, LGBTQIA+ youth, and multilingual families.

The toolkit is organized into five parts: a partnership readiness framework; partner identification and outreach tools; a Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) template; protocols for hands-on civic practice; and equity and safety design standards. Each section includes templates, checklists, and decision guides meant for hands-on use. Staff should adapt these materials to local context rather than use them word-for-word.

II. Partnership Readiness Framework

Before reaching out to any school or community organization, Network Delaware staff need to do an honest internal readiness check. One of the most common reasons partnerships stall is premature outreach: reaching out to potential partners before clarifying internal capacity,

purpose, and timeline (UCLA Center for Mental Health in Schools, 2023). The matrix below guides that self-assessment.

Table 1: Network Delaware Internal Readiness Assessment

Readiness Domain	Key Questions	Evidence Needed	Status (Complete / In Progress / Not Started)
Proposal Clarity	Can staff explain the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework in plain language to a principal or parent in under three minutes?	Tested elevator pitch; plain-language one-pager	
Civic Action Cycle Integration	Can staff articulate how a partnership activity maps to at least one stage of the Civic Action Cycle (Learn, Analyze, Organize, Act, Teach Back, Reflect)?	Completed activity-cycle mapping worksheet	
Capacity	How many active partnerships can Network Delaware currently support? Who is the designated point of contact?	Staff hours allocated; named coordinator	

Equity Infrastructure	Are materials available in languages other than English? Is there a plan for asynchronous and non-public participation pathways?	Translation capacity confirmed; participation format plan drafted	
Safety Protocol	Does Network Delaware have a written policy on protecting students who face civic risk (undocumented status, LGBTQIA+ identity, etc.)?	Written safety and confidentiality protocol	
Data and Accountability	How will Network Delaware document partnership activities and measure civic capacity growth, not just participation counts?	Evaluation framework drafted; data collection process defined	

Complete this assessment before reaching out to anyone. Jumping into outreach before the organization is ready can damage trust with schools and community partners, and those relationships are hard to repair once strained.

Table 2: Partner Readiness Screening Criteria

Not every interested school or organization will be the right starting point. These criteria help identify partners whose capacity and values are a solid match for the From Civic Learning to

Civic Power model. A low score on any criterion doesn't rule a partner out; it just signals where more relationship-building or groundwork is needed first.

Criterion	Strong Fit Indicators	Develop-First Indicators
Leadership Buy-In	Principal or executive director has explicitly expressed interest in civic education as a school or organizational priority	Leadership is open to the concept but has not yet allocated time or resources
Student/Community Voice Structures	Organization already has a student council, family advisory body, or community feedback mechanism in place	No existing participation infrastructure; would need to build from scratch
Equity Track Record	Organization has demonstrable history of serving immigrant, BIPOC, disabled, or LGBTQIA+ youth with documented outcomes	Serves these communities but lacks outcome documentation or equity-centered program design
Flexibility	Willing to adapt existing programs or schedules to pilot a new civic learning component	Programs are fixed or grant-constrained and cannot easily accommodate additions
Trust in Community	Organization is known and trusted by the communities the framework prioritizes	Organization is newer to these communities or relationship-building is still early-stage

III. Partner Identification and Outreach

Effective civic education partnerships are built on the strength of existing community relationships, not on cold institutional outreach. The National Civic League's framework for youth civic learning partnerships emphasizes that the most durable models emerge when community organizations, not schools alone, treated as co-designers of civic programming from the start (National Civic League, 2022). The following categories reflect the types of organizations best positioned to support the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework in Delaware.

A. Priority Partner Categories in Delaware

Partner Type	Role in Framework	Delaware Examples
Public Schools and LEAs	Primary setting for hands-on civic practice; provide access to students and curriculum alignment opportunities (Front 1 + Front 3)	Wilmington City Schools, Christina School District, Capital School District, Red Clay Consolidated School District
Community-Based Organizations (CBOs)	Trusted relationships with marginalized youth; bring cultural competence and organizing capacity (Front 2)	Metropolitan Wilmington Urban League, Latin American Community Center (LACC), La Esperanza, Kingswood Community Center
LGBTQIA+ Affirming Organizations	Provide safety infrastructure and non-disclosure participation pathways for LGBTQIA+ youth (Front 2 + Front 4)	Equality Delaware, United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council, I Am Me Inc., CAMP Rehoboth Community Center
Immigrant and Multilingual Serving Organizations	Facilitate language access, rights literacy, and safety-conscious civic engagement pathways (Front 2)	La Esperanza, Delaware Hispanic Commission, Catholic Charities Diocese of Wilmington

Higher Education Institutions	Research partnerships, student civic educators, and pipeline development (Front 1 + Front 3)	University of Delaware Biden School and Delaware Center for Civic Education, Delaware State University, Wesley College
Local Government and Civic Institutions	Authentic decision-making spaces for youth action (Front 3); participatory budgeting and testimony opportunities	City of Wilmington, New Castle County, Kent and Sussex County government offices, Delaware General Assembly civic engagement programs
Faith-Based and Mutual Aid Networks	Deep community trust and access to families who may be cautious about formal institutions (Front 2)	Wilmington faith-based coalitions, mutual aid networks in Wilmington and Dover

B. Initial Outreach Protocol

The steps below are adapted from the Institute for Local Government’s Governments Engaging Youth toolkit (2023), which tracked successful school-community partnership launches across California. The approach centers relationship-first outreach and clearly-defined mutual benefit.

Step	Action	Key Principle
1	Identify two to three staff contacts within the target organization through existing network relationships, not cold contact.	Warm introductions outperform institutional cold outreach by a significant margin in community trust contexts.
2	Request an informal listening conversation (30 minutes) before presenting any proposal. The goal is to understand the organization's current priorities and constraints.	Start by listening, not pitching. The framework must solve a real problem the partner already has.

3	Share a plain-language one-pager about the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework only after the listening conversation. Ask: where do you see overlap with your work?	Overlap, not add-on. The partnership must feel like a natural extension of the partner's existing mission.
4	Identify one specific, low-barrier first activity that can happen within 60 days. This builds trust before a formal MOU is signed.	Early wins create momentum. Do not start with the MOU.
5	After the first activity, debrief with the partner: what worked? what would you change? Then discuss the MOU.	Iteration before formalization. The MOU should document what already works.

C. Outreach Email Template: Community Organization

Use this template as a starting point for reaching out to a community-based organization. Adapt it to reflect the specific relationship and context; do not send it as-is.

Subject: Connecting on Youth Civic Engagement in Delaware: Conversation Request

Dear [Name],

I am reaching out from Network Delaware, where I am working on a statewide civic education initiative called From Civic Learning to Civic Power. I am in the early stages of building community partnerships and would value the chance to learn more about [Organization Name]'s work with young people in [City/Region] before I say anything about our own.

I would appreciate 30 minutes at your convenience: a listening conversation, not a pitch. I am genuinely interested in what you are seeing on the ground and where you see gaps in how young people in Delaware are supported to participate in civic life.

Thank you for your time and for the work you do.

[Your Name] | Network Delaware | [Email] | [Phone]

D. Outreach Email Template: School Administrator

Subject: Civic Education Partnership Opportunity: [School Name]

Dear Principal [Last Name],

I am writing on behalf of Network Delaware to introduce a statewide initiative focused on strengthening hands-on civic learning in Delaware schools. We believe that students learn civic skills best through real practice, not just classroom instruction, and we are looking to partner with schools ready to pilot community-rooted civic experiences.

I would welcome the opportunity to speak with you or a designated staff contact for 20 to 30 minutes to share our approach and hear more about [School Name]'s current priorities. Our model is designed to work within existing school schedules and standards; we are not asking teachers to add a course, but to connect existing learning to real community decisions.

Thank you for your leadership and for the time you invest in your students and community.

[Your Name] | Network Delaware | [Email] | [Phone]

IV. Memorandum of Understanding Template

A Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) puts the shared commitments of Network Delaware and a partner school or community organization in writing. It is not a legally binding contract, but it sets clear expectations and creates accountability on both sides. Review this template with Network Delaware leadership before use. It reflects best practices drawn from CIRCLE (2024) and the National Youth Leadership Council (2025).

Note: Sign the MOU only after at least one successful joint activity. Moving to a formal agreement before a real working relationship exists can create unnecessary friction that stalls or kills the partnership early on.

MEMORANDUM OF UNDERSTANDING

From Civic Learning to Civic Power: School and Community Partnership

This Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) is entered into between:

Network Delaware (hereinafter "Network Delaware")

AND

[Partner Organization/School] (hereinafter "Partner")

Section 1: Purpose

The purpose of this MOU is to establish a shared framework for collaboration in support of civic education and youth civic engagement in Delaware. Both parties are committed to advancing the goals of the From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework: strengthening students' ability to

think critically, organize collectively, engage in real civic decisions, and develop as civic multipliers within their families and communities.

Section 2: Shared Goals

Both parties agree that the partnership will work toward the following goals:

- Providing students with at least one hands-on civic learning experience per semester tied to a real community decision, issue, or process
- Creating participation pathways that are accessible, safe, and affirming for students who face barriers to traditional civic participation, including immigrant youth, LGBTQIA+ students, and disabled students
- Building the civic capacity of participants (defined as the ability to analyze power, organize collectively, and teach back what they have learned), not merely tracking attendance or activity completion
- Sharing outcomes data and reflections with each other at the close of each implementation cycle

Section 3: Network Delaware Commitments

Network Delaware agrees to:

- Provide a designated staff contact for the partnership, with a response time of no more than two business days for communications
- Supply curriculum resources, workshop materials, and facilitation support as agreed in the partnership work plan
- Ensure that all materials are available in English and Spanish, with additional translation support available upon request
- Maintain a written safety and confidentiality protocol protecting students whose civic participation carries personal risk
- Document activities and outcomes using a shared framework and report findings back to the partner at the close of each implementation cycle
- Seek the partner's feedback before making changes to joint program design or public communications about the partnership

Section 4: Partner Commitments

[Partner Organization/School] agrees to:

- Designate a staff liaison to coordinate with Network Delaware on scheduling, logistics, and participant preparation
- Provide access to agreed-upon student or community participants in a manner consistent with all applicable laws, policies, and parental or guardian consent requirements
- Communicate scheduling conflicts or capacity constraints with at least two weeks of advance notice where possible
- Participate in joint reflection and feedback sessions at the close of each implementation cycle
- Not share Network Delaware materials with external parties without prior written agreement

Section 5: Equity and Safety Standards

Both parties affirm that inclusion in this partnership is a design requirement, not an afterthought. Both parties commit to:

- Offering multiple participation formats (including non-public, asynchronous, and no-disclosure-required pathways) to ensure that students who face risk from visible civic participation are not excluded
- Refraining from publicizing individual student participation without documented, explicit, and voluntary consent
- Immediately notifying the other party if any situation arises that poses a safety risk to participants

Section 6: Duration and Amendment

This MOU is effective upon the date of both parties' signatures and shall remain in effect for one academic year, renewable by mutual written agreement. Either party may amend this MOU with at least 30 days' written notice and mutual consent. Either party may withdraw from the MOU with 30 days' written notice.

Signatures

Network Delaware Representative	Partner Representative
Name: _____	Name: _____
Title: _____	Title: _____
Date: _____	Date: _____
Signature: _____	Signature: _____

V. Protocols for Hands-On Civic Practice

Hands-on civic practice is the operational core of Front 3. CIRCLE research at Tufts University shows that students who engage in applied civic learning through participatory budgeting, policy simulations, community mapping, and testimony preparation, develop stronger civic knowledge, skills, and long-term participation habits than those who receive only classroom instruction (CIRCLE, 2024). The protocols below provide practical guidance for four hands-on practice modalities.

A. Participatory Budgeting (PB)

Participatory budgeting (PB) is a democratic process in which students or community members directly decide how to spend a portion of a real budget. In schools, it has been put into practice across more than 60 Arizona campuses through a partnership between the Center for the Future

of Arizona and Arizona State University, in New York City borough schools, and through Boston’s Youth Lead the Change program, where youth ages 12 to 25 allocate \$1 million of the city’s capital budget (CIRCLE, 2023). PB works particularly well with students who are often overlooked as leaders. It builds real civic power rather than just simulating it.

Phase	Description	Timeline	Who Is Responsible
1. Setup	Identify the budget source (school discretionary funds, parent association, student activity fund, or district allocation). Set the allocation amount. Establish rules and eligibility.	Weeks 1–2	Network Delaware + School/Partner Liaison
2. Issue Identification	Students identify problems or needs in their school or community through surveys, small group conversations, and community walks.	Weeks 2–3	Classroom Teacher or CBO Facilitator + Network Delaware
3. Proposal Development	Small teams develop project proposals with cost estimates. Network Delaware provides a one-page proposal template.	Weeks 3–5	Student Teams + Facilitator
4. Community Review	Proposals are reviewed by peers, family members, and school staff through open sessions. Feedback is incorporated.	Week 6	All Participants

5. Vote	All eligible participants vote. Process is transparent and documented.	Week 7	School/Partner + Network Delaware
6. Implementation and Teach-Back	Winning project is implemented. Student leads present the process and outcomes to families, peers, or the broader community.	Weeks 8–12	Student Leads + Network Delaware

Equity Note: PB processes must be designed to accommodate students who cannot participate publicly. Offer anonymous proposal submission and voting options. Ensure materials are available in all languages represented in the participating population.

B. Community Mapping

Community mapping is an investigation in which students document conditions, resources, and power dynamics in their neighborhoods using observation, interviews, photography, and geographic tools. The National Civic League has used it as an entry point for youth to connect classroom civic knowledge to their lived experience (National Civic League, 2022). Mapping projects might track air quality, sidewalk accessibility, resource distribution, or any other condition students care about in their community.

Phase	Activity	Civic Action Cycle Stage
1. Framing	Identify the question: what do we want to understand about our community?	Learn

2. Investigation	Students conduct observations, interviews, and photography in pairs or small groups.	Analyze
3. Analysis	Small groups synthesize findings: what patterns do we see? Who is most affected? What decisions shape these conditions?	Analyze
4. Action Planning	Students identify decision-makers with power to address the conditions identified. They plan a presentation, proposal, or public action.	Organize
5. Presentation	Students present findings to a relevant decision-maker (school board, city council member, neighborhood association).	Act
6. Teach-Back	Students facilitate a conversation about what they found with peers, families, or community members.	Teach Back

C. Policy Simulation

Policy simulations put students into the deliberative processes of real civic institutions such as school boards, city councils, and state legislative committees. Students take on roles, receive background materials on a genuine local issue, and work toward a decision. The Delaware Center for Civic Education runs the We the People program, which uses a legislative simulation format that builds toward mock congressional hearings. Network Delaware simulations should use real, current issues facing Delaware communities, not hypothetical scenarios.

- Select a real, current issue affecting Delaware students and communities (e.g., school budget decisions, local zoning, environmental policy)

- Assign student roles to reflect the actual stakeholder landscape: decision-makers, advocates, community members, media
- Provide background readings at appropriate reading levels, in multiple languages
- Debrief explicitly: how did the process compare to what actually happens? Who has power in real deliberations? What would change the outcome?

D. Decision-Maker Engagement

Direct engagement with real decision-makers (elected officials, school board members, city council members) ranks among the most powerful civic learning experiences students can have, especially when they show up with evidence-based proposals rather than symbolic complaints. The checklist below helps students and staff prepare for productive meetings with decision-makers.

Preparation Checklist:

- ☐ Research the decision-maker's role, jurisdiction, and current priorities
- ☐ Draft a one-page summary of your ask, evidence, and proposed action
- ☐ Rehearse your opening statement (60 seconds maximum)
- ☐ Assign roles: speaker, note-taker, timekeeper
- ☐ Establish safety protocols for students who cannot be publicly identified
- ☐ Open with a clear statement of who you are and what you are asking
- ☐ Present evidence: data, personal testimony, or community documentation
- ☐ Ask for a specific, actionable commitment, not general support
- ☐ Leave the one-page summary and contact information
- ☐ Document what was said and what was (or was not) committed to
- ☐ Send a follow-up message within 48 hours thanking the official and restating the ask
- ☐ Facilitate a debrief with students: what did we learn about how power works? What would we do differently?
- ☐ Teach back findings to peers or families

VI. Equity and Safety Design Standards

The From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework treats accessibility, dignity, and safety as infrastructure, not optional accommodations. Equity design should be embedded into every partnership activity from the start, not bolted on at the end. The standards below apply to all Network Delaware partnership work and are drawn from the framework's eight guiding principles and from current best practices in safety-conscious civic engagement with communities facing real risk.

A. Safety-Conscious Design: Required Standards

Standard	What It Requires in Practice
No-Disclosure-Required Participation	Every activity must offer a pathway for students to participate without disclosing immigration status, gender identity, sexual orientation, disability, or family situation. Anonymous options must be available for all surveys, proposals, and votes.
Language Access	All written materials distributed to students or families must be available in English and Spanish at minimum. Network Delaware will identify translation partners for additional languages based on the demographics of each partner's community. Language access is treated as a non-negotiable, not an optional accommodation.
Asynchronous and Non-Public Participation	No activity design should require students to participate in public-facing civic spaces. Asynchronous alternatives (written submissions, video recordings, online participation) must be available for every activity that involves public testimony, public mapping, or decision-maker engagement.
Informed Consent and Confidentiality	Parents, guardians, and students must receive clear information about what the partnership involves, what data will be collected, who will see it, and how their information will be protected. Consent processes must be available in all relevant languages.

Do-No-Harm Review	Before launching any new activity, Network Delaware staff should ask: could this activity put any participating student at risk of immigration enforcement, outing, harassment, or retaliation? If yes, modify the design before proceeding.
-------------------	--

B. Community-Specific Considerations

Community	Key Considerations for Partnership Design
Immigrant and Mixed-Status Families	Prioritize rights-literacy components. Ensure that no activity requires students or families to disclose status. Work with trusted community organizations (e.g., La Esperanza, LACC) as trusted intermediaries rather than leading outreach directly. Know your local Know Your Rights resources.
Black and Brown Youth	Center organizing, accountability, and collective power, not assimilation into existing civic structures. Use community mapping and participatory budgeting as entry points. Avoid deficit framing. Source local mentors and civic models from within these communities.
Hispanic and Latino Communities	Do not treat Latino communities as monolithic. Distinguish among Afro-Latino, Indigenous, multi-generational, recent immigrant, and U.S.-born populations. Language access must reflect this diversity. Work with community organizations with existing trust relationships.
Disabled Students and Families	Ensure that all meeting spaces, materials, and activities are physically and cognitively accessible. Offer participation in multiple formats. Avoid designing activities where physical presence is the only way to participate. Include disabled students in activity design, not just as recipients.

LGBTQIA+ Youth	Partner with affirming organizations (Equality Delaware, United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council, I Am Me Inc.) for activities serving LGBTQIA+ youth. Never require self-identification for participation. Offer participation pathways that do not require public visibility. Train all partner staff in LGBTQIA+ affirming communication.
Multilingual Families	Language access is civic infrastructure. Translate all materials. Provide interpretation at family-facing events. Work with community liaisons who speak languages other than Spanish, particularly for Arabic, Haitian Creole, and Indigenous-language communities in Delaware.

VII. Measuring Partnership Outcomes

The From Civic Learning to Civic Power framework measures success by what participants can actually do, analyze, and teach others, not by how many showed up. Network Delaware should push back against output-only reporting (workshops delivered, students served) and use the framework below to track real civic capacity growth across the partnership.

Outcome Domain	Indicators of Civic Capacity Growth	Data Collection Method
Civic Knowledge	Can participants explain how a real decision they engaged with was made? Can they identify who holds power in that process?	Pre-/post-reflection prompt; exit ticket; facilitated debrief notes
Civic Analysis	Can participants identify which stakeholders benefit from current conditions and which do not? Can they name at least one point of leverage for change?	Power mapping activity; written or verbal reflection

Organizing Capacity	Did participants take on leadership roles within the activity? Did they recruit or include others?	Facilitator observation notes; participant role documentation
Civic Action	Did participants engage with a real decision-making space (testimony, vote, proposal, meeting)?	Activity log; documentation of artifacts produced
Teach-Back	Did participants share what they learned with at least one other person (family member, peer, or community member) outside the program?	Teach-back activity documentation; participant self-report
Reflection and Iteration	Can participants identify what worked, what they would change, and what they want to do next?	End-of-cycle reflection form; partner debrief notes

Share evaluation data with the partner at the end of each cycle and use it to shape the next one.

This feedback loop (evaluate, adapt, improve) is baked into the Civic Action Cycle's Reflect and Iterate stage. Treat it as real partnership work, not a paperwork requirement.

VIII. Quick Reference: Partnership Checklist

Use this checklist to track partnership status. Complete it jointly with the partner liaison.

Stage	Task	Complete?
Pre-Launch	Network Delaware internal readiness assessment completed	☐

Pre-Launch	Partner identified through warm introduction	☐
Pre-Launch	Listening conversation conducted (no pitch)	☐
Pre-Launch	Overlap between partner priorities and framework confirmed	☐
Pre-Launch	First joint activity identified and scheduled	☐
Launch	Equity and safety design review conducted for first activity	☐
Launch	Materials translated into relevant languages	☐
Launch	Consent and confidentiality protocols communicated to participants	☐
Launch	First activity delivered and documented	☐
Formalization	Joint debrief on first activity conducted	☐
Formalization	MOU drafted and reviewed by both parties	☐
Formalization	MOU signed and filed	☐
Ongoing	Partnership work plan established with clear activity timeline	☐

Ongoing	Mid-cycle check-in conducted with partner liaison	☐
Close-Out	End-of-cycle evaluation completed	☐
Close-Out	Data shared with partner	☐
Close-Out	Decision made on renewal or redesign for next cycle	☐

Works Cited

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Growing Voters Year-Round: Program Examples to Build Youth Engagement." Tufts University, 7 Sept. 2023,

circle.tufts.edu/latest-research/growing-voters-year-round-program-examples-build-youth-engagement.

Center for Information and Research on Civic Learning and Engagement (CIRCLE). "Equitable K-12 Civic Learning." Tufts University, 2024,

circle.tufts.edu/our-research/equitable-k12-civic-learning.

Delaware Center for Civic Education. University of Delaware Biden School, 2025, udel.edu/academics/colleges/biden-school/research-public-service/ipa/public-service/dcce/.

Institute for Local Government. "Governments Engaging Youth Toolkit." ca-ilg.org/governments-engaging-youth-toolkit. Accessed 20 Apr. 2025.

Kawashima-Ginsberg, Kei, and Alberto Medina. "How Educators and Policymakers Can Prepare Young People to Engage in the 2024 Election." Brookings Institution, 22 Aug. 2024, brookings.edu/articles/how-educators-and-policymakers-can-prepare-young-people-to-engage-in-the-2024-election/.

National Civic League. "Creating Partnerships for Effective Youth Civic Learning." National Civic Review, 5 Aug. 2022, nationalcivicleague.org/ncr-article/creating-partnerships-for-effective-youth-civic-learning/.

National Youth Leadership Council. "The Hidden Costs of Poor Service-Learning Experiences: Why Quality Matters." 2025, nylc.org.

Participatory Budgeting Project. "Participatory Budgeting in Schools: A Policy Scan." 2020, participatorybudgeting.org/wp-content/uploads/2022/03/PB-in-Schools-Policy-Scan-2020.pdf.

United Way of Delaware PRIDE Council. "LGBTQ Education, Health and Family Resources." uwde.org/how-we-work/affinity-groups/pride-council/lgbtq-education-health-and-family-resources/. Accessed 20 Apr. 2025.

UCLA Center for Mental Health in Schools. "School-Community Partnerships: A Guide." smhp.psych.ucla.edu/pdfdocs/partnership/scpartnerships.pdf. Accessed 20 Apr. 2025.